"I dare say that there isn't much happening in the male actor space," says Vidya Balan. "It is a better time to be a female actor today. Look at the kind of female roles you get to see. Every actress is doing interesting work." Balan is undoubtedly on point here. From Deepika Padukone in *Gehraiyaan* (2022) and Alia Bhatt in *Gangubai Kathiawadi* (2022) to Taapsee Pannu in the upcoming *Shabaash Mithu*, the present ubiquity of female protagonists seems proof that more women are being given the parts they need to flex their acting muscles. Over the years, as Balan won acclaim for performances in films like *The Dirty Picture* (2011) and *Tumhari Sulu* (2017), she championed the cause of female-driven narratives. One might even say it was Balan who helped a small shift build into a sizeable wave.

Even though Balan doesn't see herself as a torchbearer, she has certainly inspired a whole generation of actresses to seek parts that are worthy of their talent. For Pannu, Balan's rise is proof "that [success] can happen despite being so unconventional". She says, "Suddenly, the stories felt different, you had a female POV [point of view], the gaze was different. She isn't your regular diva of Bollywood."

Despite several pressures, Balan has staunchly refused to conform to industry diktats that define who or what a heroine should be. On the rare occasion that she has capitulated, the films have failed to do justice to her prowess. Balan's fame, one sees, has resulted from projects that she approached with an unwavering passion and sincerity. "I get bored very easily, so I am looking for new stories to tell and characters to play all the time," she says. "My work has always been an extension of my beliefs. It's this hunger that propels me forward." That perhaps explains how the actress is able to still make new her portrayal of womanhood's many facets, even 17 years after *Parineeta*, her Hindi film debut.

Balan says her latest film, the drama thriller *Jalsa* (streaming on Amazon Prime Video from March 18), gives her that rare opportunity to "delve into the grey". Balan's character, renowned journalist Maya Menon, is faced with a moral reckoning when her junior colleague (Vidhatri Bandi) inches closer to the truth of a hit-and-run accident. "[Maya] takes great pride in the fact that she chases the truth, no matter what the cost," says Balan. "She is a credible voice in the media but with this accident, she is left feeling confused, scared and insecure. What is fascinating about her is the quandary she is in."

Initially, Balan had turned down director Suresh Triveni when he asked her to play Menon. "I didn't think I had the courage to play her," she says. "But the pandemic changed so much; it made us look at ourselves and life differently. I suddenly had empathy for her." The past two years have also made Balan appreciate the virtues of streaming platforms—the "longevity" they promise, the accessibility they afford vis-à-vis theatres. After *Shakuntala Devi* (2020) and *Sherni* (2021), *Jalsa* is her third consecutive film to opt for an OTT release. "With anything new, there's a lot of uncertainty and lack of understanding, but now people have seen its benefits. I am a prime example of that," admits Balan.

While OTT has ensured that Balan's work gets the audience it merits, it has also given the careers of many actors a new lease of life. One of them is Balan's *Jalsa* co-star, Shefali Shah. Her role in *Delhi Crime* (2019—) was a game-changer, resulting in the actress being busier than she has ever been before. Balan, who, like Shah, started her career in television, has been following her colleague's work: "I'm so glad there are roles worthy of her [talent]. She's being given a wide canvas to paint on."

At 43, Balan, too, is revelling in the opportunities coming her way. This, after all, is a creatively lucrative period for actresses, regardless of their age. "I don't think it is a phase or trend. I think it is here to stay," she says. "That's also because women are now in charge of their lives, they are owning their bodies and choices, or at least attempting to do so." Balan feels roles for women are getting better because they reflect our larger reality—"There is no one prototype of a woman we aspire to anymore." ■

–Suhani Singh



In her latest film Jalsa (streaming on Amazon Prime Video from March 18), **VIDYA BALAN'S** journalist character is faced with a moral reckoning